

Sierra Challenge 2010 – Days 7-9 (of 10)

August 12th to 14th

The Sierra Challenge is an event which has been going on for the last 10 years run by a man named Bob Burd. The concept is 10 peaks done in 10 days and instead of doing this as a backpack each day starts and ends at the cars.



To quote the Bob himself:

"The Sierra Challenge is a series of ten consecutive dayhikes to some of the most challenging peaks in the Sierra Nevada range. The peaks for the 2010 event were chosen based on several criteria: they don't appear on previous Challenges; they hold special interest to the organizer; they are demanding dayhikes, much like the [2001](#), [2002](#), [2003](#), [2004](#), [2005](#), [2006](#), [2007](#) [2008](#), and [2009](#) events that preceded it. They average 15 miles of hiking/climbing, with an average of 5,330ft elevation gain. Not unlike climbing Half Dome, but more off-trail, more technically demanding, and at higher elevation. This year's list does not include some of the super-long or super-gain hikes as they have in the past - I got tired of hiking those by myself. :-)"

Due to having committed to a trip the previous weekend and a lack of vacation days (due to all the other trips I'm doing this year) I was only able to participate in the last four days. The last was relatively easy but I had to drop out due to a rather annoying illness. Fortunately I was able to do the hardest day.

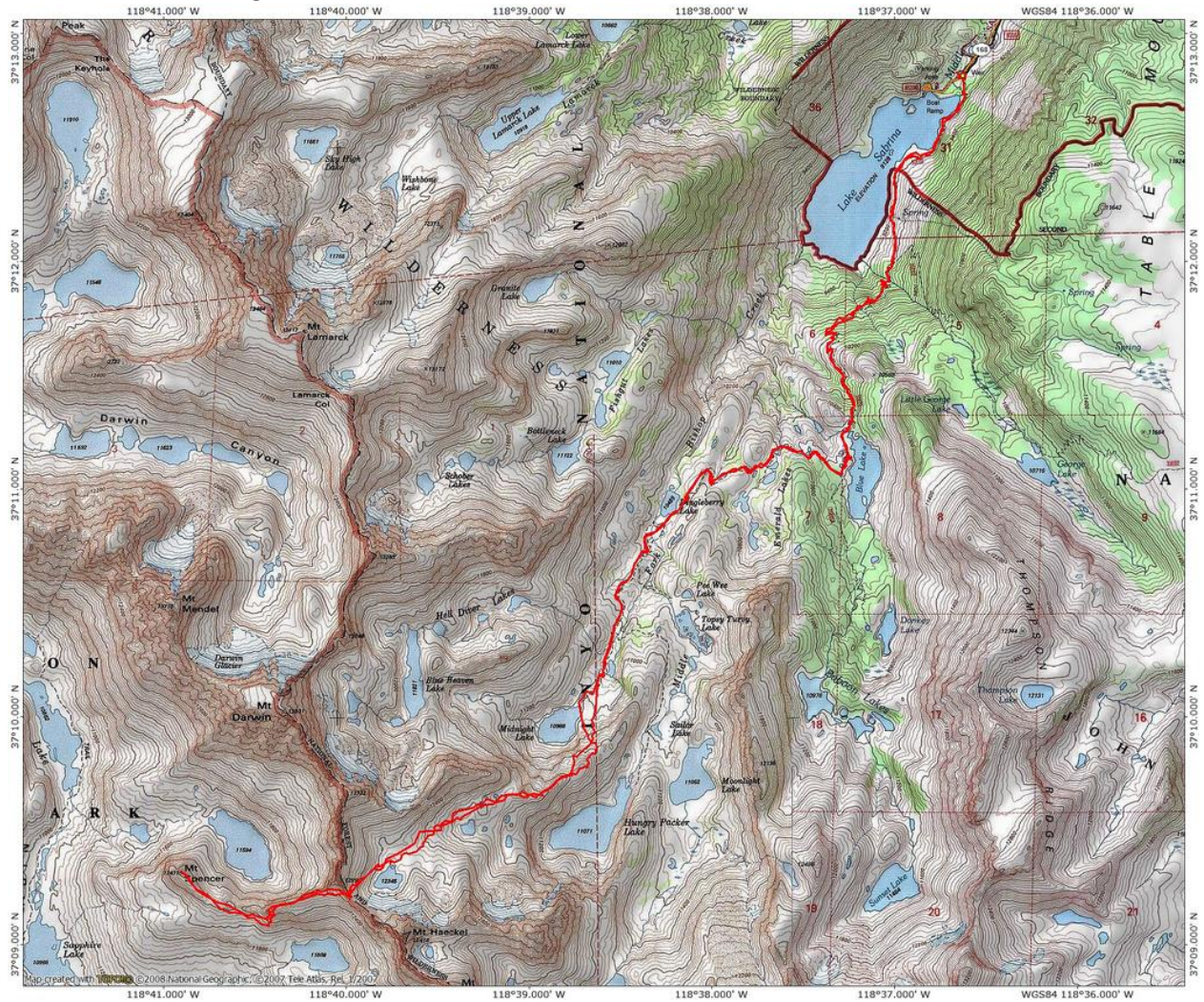
Web Resources:

<http://www.snwburd.com/bob/challenge/2010/>

<http://www.summitpost.org/phpBB2/viewtopic.php?t=52439&postdays=0&postorder=asc&start=90&sid=9e6bc605ecea2c966ac98e63fdb5654e>

Day One: Mt Spencer from Lake Sabrina

22.4 miles, 5600 ft of gain. 11 hours 31 minutes



I drove up from Orange County to Bishop Wednesday afternoon and rolled in to town a bit after dark. After stopping at the local supermarket for supplies I drove up to North Lake and fell asleep in my vehicle.



Thursday morning the hike started at 6 am at the nearby Lake Sabrina Trailhead. I recognized exactly one person, Ron Hudson, and everyone else was brand new to me. Perfect!



I'd been here before for a trip last year so I was familiar with the initial part of the trail. Feeling fresh and having spent the last few weekends at altitude I tagged along at the very front and got to know Shawn and Tricia as we took the initial gain at a decent enough clip.



The first 7 miles or so were a quick run up a trail to Midnight Lake. At that point we hopped on a ridge and the real fun started as the route turned into somewhat rocky cross country scrambling.



Tricia hoping onto a slab.



Looking back at Midnight Lake below.



Gain? What gain?



We were aiming for Haeckel Col and we stopped a moment at the small body of water below to top off our water bottles. I gave up on filtering completely this weekend due to the fact I didn't want to carry the weight of a filter and there just wasn't enough time.

Other than having to avoid the snow the passage over Haeckel Col it wasn't bad. I slowed down a bit as the injuries from a few weeks back tend to hurt when I do big rock moves and ended up hooking up with another hiker named Phil from South Carolina.

We finished the approach and went over the top of Haeckel Col.



If you can't see Mt Spencer I'm not surprised. It's in the foreground after the ridge meanders to the right. Not quite the most impressive of sights and I thought from here it would just be an easy jaunt out the ridge.

Of course this being the Sierra it wasn't that easy. We got about 2/3 of the way down the ridge and were suddenly faced with a cliff. After a bit of poking around I led the way down climbing this:



It was actually an interesting 3rd class-ish down climb that spiced up the route quite a bit.

After climbing back up the far side and reaching the somewhat less than impressive summit I was surprised to find an old school Sierra Club register box



And looking at the summit register itself it appears the peak gets a surprising number of visitors. I have no idea why.



I was with three other folks at that point, Phil, Vitaley, and Adam. We took our time singing the register, eating, and taking pictures.



The view wasn't bad though out little peak was rather eclipsed by the others in the area.



Heading back was uneventful outside of getting to climb back up that fun 3rd-ish class section. Crossing back over the col we dropped down to the small lakes below and happened upon Trisha who had dropped off from a group ahead who traversed over to another nearby peak. Further down we also came upon Ron Hudson who had done the SPS peak Haeckel instead of Spencer.



Our bolstered group had a rapid but social hike out. The one break we took was enough to expose us to the still numerous mosquitoes and for the most part we kept moving.



We arrived back at the cars rather tired with the GPS reading 22.4 miles. That was a bit longer than the advertised 17 miles but ah well. We were all surprised at how hard the day had felt compared to what we expected looking at the stats.

After lounging for a bit at the cars with Trisha and Vitaley commenting on our sore feet I ran down the hill to resupply in Bishop before heading to the next trailhead.

The advantage of doing these peaks as day hike was the opportunity to eat in town each evening. At Ron Hudson's suggestion I went to the new Bishop Chinese food buffet which turned into a good fit for post- hike food cravings.

After dinner and another stop by the store I headed back up the hill and found Trisha and the others already asleep and parked at South Lake. All other spots being taken I pulled into a No Overnight Parking spot (it was late and my vehicle was occupied) and crawled in the back to fall asleep.

That was when something weird happened.

I was asleep when around 10:45 pm the sound of a heavy diesel engine woke me up. It stopped nearby and I heard two people get out and start talking. I wasn't fully awake yet but I could hear them discussing the vehicles parked in the no overnight parking.

The two voices who I'd soon label yokel #1 and yokel #2 commented on the number of vehicles in the no overnight parking. One commented on the silver vehicle (my Rav4) and a light shined in the window where they apparently caught sight of me sleeping because they backed off rather quickly. Instead they went down the line of cars and apparently stopped between Bob and Trisha's cars. Trisha was asleep

inside but had the windows cracked while Bob was bivving off in the bushes. The two yokels proceeded to argue over which car was “gayer”, Trisha’s element or Bob’s car, and then off all things threw fresh feces on Bob’s windshield.



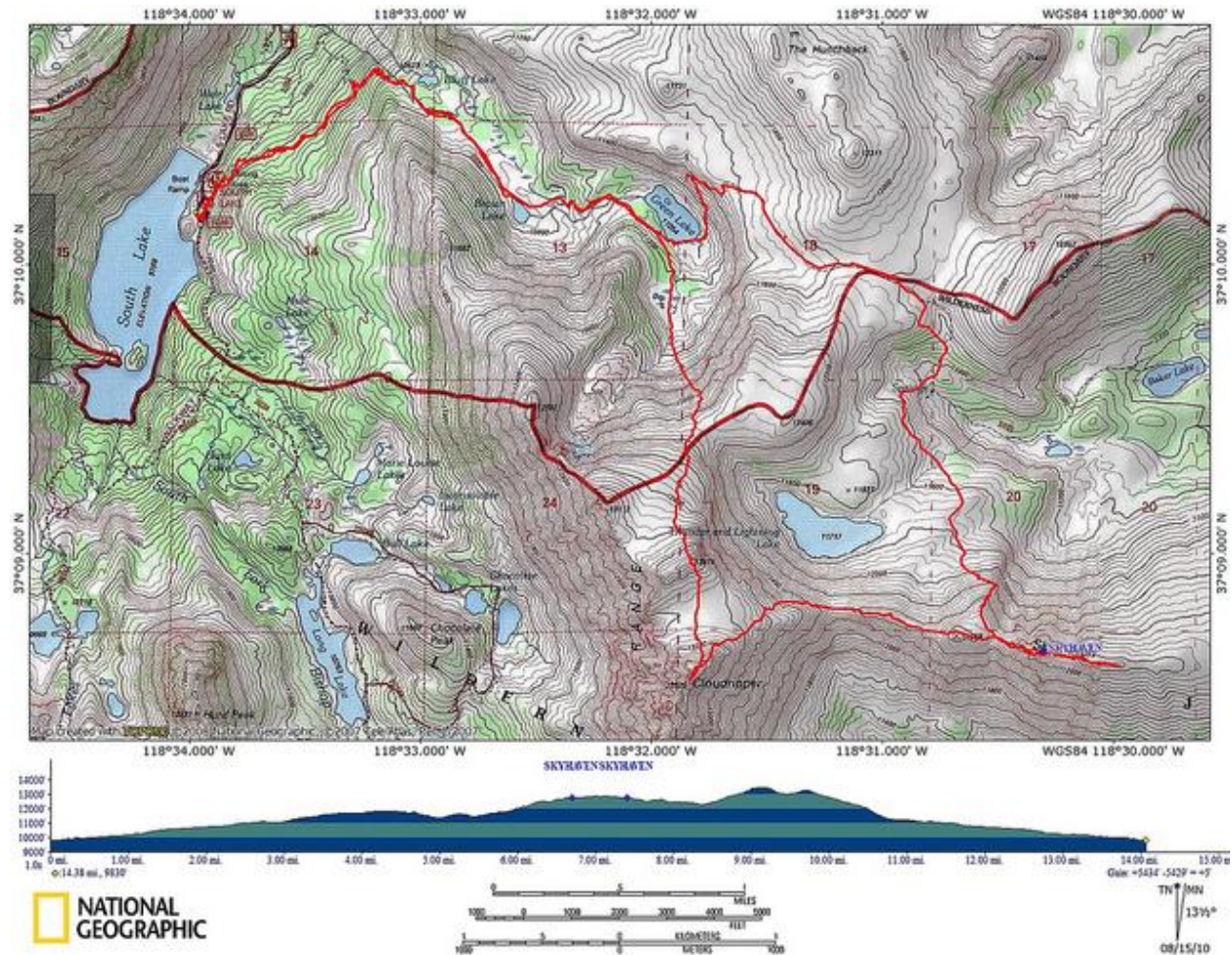
I have no idea where they got the feces, who they were, or what the heck their problem was. They took off apparently saying something about returning at 12.

I was up by this time and walked over to Trisha’s car. We found out what had happened to Bob’s car and set out rousing the folks around us and relocating to down the hill before the jerks came back.

Needless to say it wasn’t the most restful of nights.

Day 2: Sky Haven From South Lake

15 miles, 5400 ft of gain. 12 hours.



So after the adventure of the night before we ended up sleeping down the road near a local resort and I awoke bright and early to drive back to the South Lake trailhead for another 6 am trail time.

Due to the parking lot being completely full Tricia actually missed the start time and hiked part way by herself. I followed the group and we proceeded to climb right from the parking lot up something called the Pipe Trail. This would be due to the fact you walk up balancing on a somewhat dilapidated pipe.



We were headed up Bishop Pass and the trail was pretty gentle. I took it a bit slower this morning but ended up tagging the heels of the front group again.



We eventually had a decent climb and ended up in a wide open area where we caught our breath.



We made the top of the pass and looked down at the altitude we'd have to lose before climbing our peak.



With a collective groan we started off down the slope.



Much traversing later we reached the start of the real climb to the peak.



Ron Hudson took the intelligent route and climbed a gently ramp further to the west. The rest of us...didn't. Sometime later, dirtier, and a small bit wiser we were on top of the ridge looking at a rather interesting 3rd class+ climb to the summit.



There was some fun 3rd class and I strayed into a 4th-ish class face for a while.



Some folks purposefully took the hard route...



So after that bit of fun we arrived up top and triumphantly received our reward: An awesome view of the Palisades.



I'd actually been up the second peak from the right last year when I led a private climb of Winchell. It was rather awesome to get the bird's eye view of the area.

Bob Burd and company had set out further down the ridge to a rather boring looking high point. After consulting our maps and GPS's we all agreed that both Mr. Garmin and Bob's indicator on the map showed our current bump was the summit. Nevertheless Bob and company rolled back by and declared that the highpoint of the ridge was the actual summit. Grumbling we continued on to a rather boring

“real” summit.



Bleh, I'll take the first point any day.

So both summits conquered I teamed up with Darija and Erik (whose first day was today after flying in from Seattle) and we decided that instead of dropping down to the trail we'd traverse a ridge and pick up two bonus peaks, Vagabond and the SPS peak Cloudripper.

Darija and I were a bit low on fluids but fortunately Erik was willing to share.



The traverse was a pain but we made a beeline for a snow patch on the far side several hundred feet below Cloudripper where we were finally able to regain some fluid.

We made the summit of Cloudripper which despite a rather boring approach had a slightly exposed summit rock that made for a decent picture.



Next we dropped down and continued across to Vagabond. Nothing special here.

From here we had two options: a longer traverse over to pick up the trail at the pass or a shorter yet rougher drop down a chute to hit the trail below the pass.



We picked the latter much to Erik's eventual displeasure. The rocks were loose and required constant attention and there were a few spills.



Darija wasn't feeling well and took off ahead while I trailed back with Erik who was having a hell of a time with loose rocks.

A few hours later we rapidly descended back down the pipe and returned to our cars 12 hours after having left.

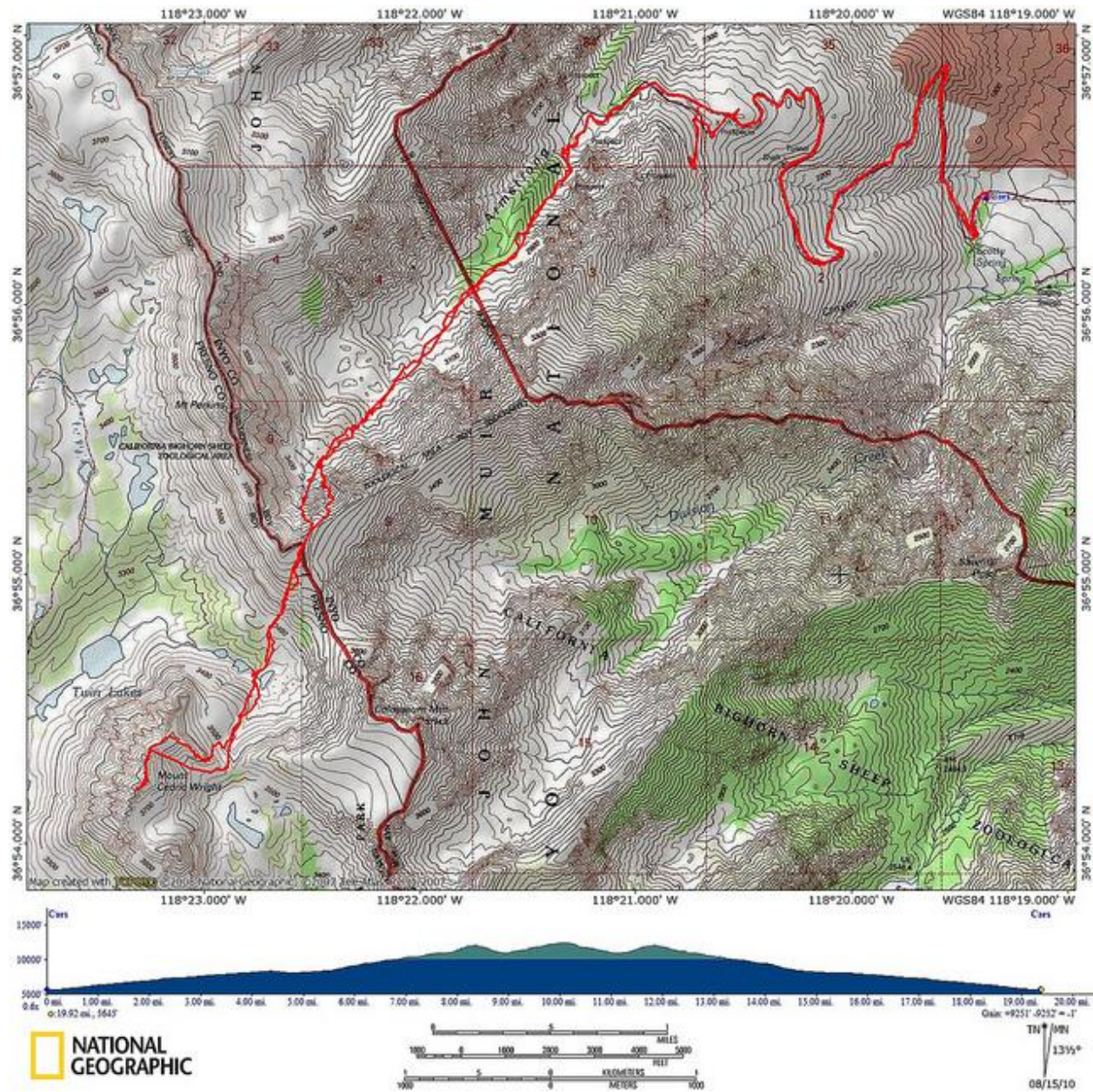


Erik was nice enough to offer me use of his shower so I tailed him down the hill and divested myself of two days worth of dirt.

After eating for the second time at the new Bishop Chinese buffet I set off south for the next somewhat obscure trailhead. I arrived around 10 pm, found Trisha's car, and went to sleep doing my best to ignore the stream of cars passing by looking for the trailhead.

Cedric Wright via Armstrong Canyon

20 miles, 8600 ft of gain. 17 hours.



Trail time was 5 am due to the length of the hike and I'd promised Trisha a ride of the remainder of the road to the trailhead. So I was up early to get my coffee made and all the morning rituals out of the way. Not nearly enough sleep but that's life in the mountains.

It was still dark when we found the others and shouldered our packs.



The initial climb was actually rather pleasant, just steady gain up a trail.



I zoned out and got into a rhythm and promptly followed the frontrunners up the wrong trail. We dropped down a few hundred feet and grabbed the correct trail. I now went from in the front to almost dead last. I resigned myself to a long day of solo hiking.

The trail turned into cross country...



...which then became a moraine.



Moraines are a collection of loose rocks scattered almost at random and prone to shifting other than ones feet. That means at any given moment you need to be ready to leap from your current rock to another as it shifts and tries to smash your femur into dust.

Progress slowed but I caught sight of two different folks ahead of me. Unfortunately it also brought the chute we'd be climbing into view.



As I rounded the last corner the screams of “ROCK!” and the sound of large rocks bounding down a slope reached me. This was going to be fun...

I actually ran into Trisha again at the bottom. Having just recovered from a rather nasty injury due to rock fall on Tahquitz resulting in a “minor” lung puncture (who knew those came in minor!) and a few broken ribs she wisely decided the peak wasn’t worth it.

Smart lady. Unfortunately despite very competent parents I’m apparently not that bright. After chatting with her for a bit I took off up the chute and cut left into some 3rd class rock hoping to avoid the rock fall.

I did avoid the rocks but unfortunately the area I climbed was very loose and even the occasional solid rock was covered in a layer of dirt and loose rock. A number of Oh Sh!t moments ensued.



Sometime later I arrived up top rather happy to be alive and telling myself I would not down climb that same route.



To my surprise I actually ran into three others from the Challenge at the top of the chute. There was Faith and her boyfriend Dirk complete with a rather awesome wizard hat and Ingrid who had similarly climbed that mess behind me expecting to be up there solo.

Well, at least I wouldn't be hiking alone. I teamed up with Ingrid for the rest of the day though we were usually in shouting distance of Faith and Dirk.

We descended down the far side of the ridge to a small lake where we actually ran into Bob Burd and company. For some reason later Bob would only remember running into me. This would be important due to a miscommunication that resulted in several folks thinking Ingrid had turned back below the chute and the local sheriff being notified. Oops.



We could now see our peak and with renewed purpose set off up the slopes.



Again our peak was dwarfed by its neighbors and generally in the middle of nowhere. It was a second class climb to the ridge and then it became a much more fun easy 3rd route.



Once we made the ridge I had much more fun though the weather turned hazy and we could smell smoke on the wind. We never figured out where exactly the fire was but one side of the ridge had very limited visibility.



Sometime after 2 pm we made our summit and found the register placed by someone only 9 days before.



Some of us posed heroically...



Some of us had a beer with loved ones...



And some of us took a nap...



It was all well earned.

However, we were only half way at this point and had one hell of a climb and descent ahead of us.

Reluctantly we set off, returning down the ridge and descending a rather pleasant scree slope before filling up our water bottles again at the lower lake.



The climb was relatively painless and soon we were at the top. I asked Ingrid where she had climbed up and after a short consultation where I did not double check my map we set off down.

Oops.

It started off painlessly enough.



Then we hit this:



I did some rather hairy down climbing that now tops my list of things I never care to do again.

But then I was down and after doing a somewhat less than graceful if effective descent of a steep snowfield without an ice axe we were on the moraine looking back at the hated chutes.



We made the top of the trail around dark. Unfortunately this put us 5 miles and several thousand feet above where our cars were parked.

Ingrid and I did the descent quickly but it still took quite a while. We reached the cars at 10 pm to find that Ingrid's worried carpool buddy Kevin under the mistaken notion that she had turned back late that morning and as a result had actually notified authorities about a missing hiker. It actually took until the following morning to get that completely sorted out.

We drove for Lone Pine which was the access point for the final day of the challenge, hoping to find something open foodwise.

Sadly even the "Always Open" Sierra Café was closed leaving...McDonalds. Against my better judgment I grabbed a grilled chicken sandwich and fries. Even as deprived of real food as I was I could hardly choke it down and quickly drove out to Alabama Hills to pass out.

Mt. Morgenson

?? miles ,?? gain. 3 hours of shakes and cold sweats

I slept for maybe 3 or 4 hours in Alabama Hills before driving to Whitney Portal, shoving all my food and smelly items into a bear box, and stumbling over to meet the rest of the group. I wasn't feeling great but that's never stopped me before and this was the final day and decidedly easier than the previous few.



I cleared up the confusion over the previous say and assured everyone that both Ingrid and myself had made it out safely.



The North Fork trail climbed rather quickly.



And there were a sizable amount of rocks to boost up.



In several places there was water running over the trail and one fair sized waterfall.



I stuck with the group through Lower Boy Scout Lake where I finally had to face the fact I just wasn't feeling right. Shakes and a cold sweat was making it hard to even enjoy myself and I'm the sort that actually enjoys flinging myself up steep mountains as god-awful hours every weekend. I waited a bit and eventually decided I just wasn't having fun and there was little point in continuing.

Reluctantly I turned around. My little toe had one hell of a blister from the previous day and even through the layers of athletic tape it was hurting me quite a bit.



I made it back to my car and headed into town for some real food. That made me feel better and I started the long drive home from Lone Pine.

It was actually rather nice to get home at a relatively decent time as opposed to my usual 1 am arrivals followed by a 4 am wakeup to catch a plane.

I had a great time participating in the Challenge and though it was advertised as the 10th and last Challenge rumor has it that it will continue next year. I met a bunch of really neat people and I have every intention of doing the entire 10 days next year assuming I can afford the vacation time.